

LAUNCH PAD · A GUIDE'S LESSON PLAN BOOK

The Forge Year

What is worth solving?

A guide's book for Year Two of the Launch Pad, written so a learner can read every page.

VIBRANT LIFE

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A note before you begin

This book is the plan for The Forge - the second of the three Launch Pad years. It is written for the guide who runs the year, and it is written so that any learner can pick it up and read the whole thing. There is nothing hidden in here.

The seam rule: everything in this book is safe and honest for a learner to read. Nothing in it manages or manipulates anyone. Lines in “quotes” are things a guide might say aloud. Everything else is for the guide to understand and hold - the reasons behind the moves, the care points, the things to watch for. A learner who reads a guide’s note will find a grown-up thinking carefully and kindly about how to be useful, never a grown-up figuring out how to steer them.

If you are a learner reading this: welcome. This is your year, and you are allowed to see how it was built. At the end of the year you will even be asked to help rebuild it for the next group.

Joining at the Forge (a note for a learner starting here)

You do not have to have done the first year (Origin) to start The Forge. Some learners begin their Launch Pad story right here, and that is a real beginning, not a late one.

Origin does one quiet job: it gives a person three things to stand on. The Forge leans on those three things, so if you are joining here, you will build a short, compressed version of them in your own work time over the first few weeks. In plain terms, the three things are:

- **A self named** - some sense of who you are and what you dream about. You will do a fast version of naming your own dreams.
- **Agency claimed** - the felt knowledge that your choices matter and that you can move some things in your life. You will take a quick inventory of what you actually have to work with.
- **A routine that holds** - a rhythm for your days that fits you, so the work has somewhere to live.

You will build these in your self-guided blocks across the first three weeks. They are re-enterable, never a test, and never something anyone grades. By the time the group names the problem each person will carry, you will have enough of “what’s mine” to name a problem that is genuinely yours. In the shared work, you are a full Forge learner from the very first day. There is no catch-up table.

Part 1 - For everyone: what this year is

The year's question

The Forge asks one thing, all year: **What is worth solving?**

The first year was about dreaming your life - figuring out who you are. This year is about building - turning your gaze outward, from yourself to the world and the problems in it. You will find a real problem that matters to you, trace it down to its root, and act on it alongside the people who actually have it.

The anchor line for the year is simple: **things are only impossible until they're not.**

The journey (the arc, plain)

Here is the shape of the whole year, in order:

1. **Name a real problem.** Learn the difference between a problem you can act on and a thing you just have to accept. Name your problem so precisely that it stops being a fog and becomes a thing you can actually fight.
2. **Trace it to its root.** The obvious villain is almost never the real cause. You will learn to keep asking “why” until you hit the system underneath - and to ask who is still accountable inside that system, including, sometimes, you.
3. **Find your arena.** Not every problem is yours to move. You will find the slice of it where your own action actually changes something, and win a small thing you can feel.
4. **Lift your eyes to the world.** You will go out and meet real problems where they live, and choose the one that breaks your heart - not the one you think you should care about, the one that actually moves you.
5. **Play the long game.** Big problems are systems, not single heroic acts. You will break the impossible into a next doable step, find the real leverage, and gather people.

6. **Put your hands to work.** You will act, for real, with real people - designing the work *with* them, never *for* them.
7. **Make a room care.** You will stand up and make the case: here is a problem worth solving, here is why it broke my heart, here is what I did, here is what I ask of you.

The three years together move like this: first you look at yourself, then you look at the world, and in the final year you learn to make the hard call when there is no easy answer. This is the middle year - the turn outward.

What you make and carry

The Captain's Log. You have one artifact that travels with you across all three years - the Captain's Log. You name it yourself. It is yours. A guide never reads it to grade you or check up on you. The moment a Log becomes something a grown-up inspects, the whole trust of this place breaks, so it does not happen. You capture your year in it however you hold things best.

If you are joining this year, your Log starts now, on your first day, same first page everyone else started with. Every Log starts empty. Yours starts now.

The Vineyard. Alongside the Log runs a second thread called the Vineyard. It was planted in the very first week of Origin, on the same morning the Captain's Log was named - the two are twins. The Log is the self examined; the Vineyard is the self delighted. The Vineyard is whatever you tend purely because you love it, for no useful reason at all - a garden, a song you are learning, a craft, a friendship, a wandering. Nobody harvests it. Nobody asks you to write a reflection on it. Nobody makes it count for anything. The instant someone tries to make the Vineyard *useful*, it dies. It is here because the whole point of this formation is to make the hard call **and still love your life** - and that half of the thing cannot wait for the last year. If you are joining this year, you name your own Vineyard-thing now, too.

The promises

Under everything in this year sit six promises. They are the floor. Nothing here is allowed to break them:

1. **No grades or completion scores** that anyone but you can see.
2. **No ranking, no leaderboards, no comparing your progress to anyone else's** in public.
3. **No one deposits knowledge into you.** You make meaning; the guide does not author your answers for you.

4. **No outside deadlines forced on you.** You set your pace. “I didn’t get to it” is honored, not punished.
5. **No treating how much you produce as your worth.** A quest you abandoned and learned from counts every bit as much as one you finished.
6. **No surveillance.** Your data belongs to you, not the school.

And one more, the biggest: **you have the right to refuse.** You may decline any quest, and you will be fully honored for it, never coded as a failure or a dropout. More on how that works below.

How we work

The week. The week has a steady rhythm:

- **Monday and Wednesday** are your own. You run your own hours - core academics, your personal project, your writing, whatever you set for yourself. The guide is not on the floor these days; that absence is part of the lesson. You are learning that you can hold your own time. Around midday there is a check-in.
- **Tuesday** is a lighter guided day - games, group challenges, hands-on work, planning for expeditions, and shared meals.
- **Thursday** is the one deep guided day - the week’s serious block, where the harder thinking happens.
- **Friday** is fallow. It is protected and celebrated and never filled. Rest, play, friendship, making things for no reason. This is a practice, not a reward. It is for you and for the guide both.

This year runs a little lighter than the others on purpose. The guide is running the studio solo while raising a small child, and the shape of the year is named honestly to everyone: one deep day, one lighter day. The depth cut is real and owned, not a quiet slide. That honesty - choosing the sustainable shape and saying so out loud - is itself part of what this place teaches.

The Log, captured however you hold it. You capture your Captain’s Log in whatever way fits you. Written on paper, spoken aloud and recorded, drawn, dictated, typed, or told to a scribe - no form is the lesser Log. The one who draws their year is not doing a smaller thing than the one who writes it. Capture the way your mind actually works.

How “no” works here. You may decline any quest. When you do, you name your reason - not because you have to justify yourself to earn the right to refuse, but because naming the reason is a way of thinking clearly. The guide might ask you a Socratic question about it - something like

“when do you think you’ll first run into this for real?” - but that question is a mirror, not a test you can fail. The guide has a voice, never a veto. Your reasoned “no” stands after the questioning. A guide can never overrule your reason.

When someone says no, it is received in three beats, and the guide will know this shape: first, the no is received whole and honored, before anything else - “Okay. You’re not doing this one.” Second, the door is offered once, without a push - “if you ever want to tell me what’s behind that, I’d genuinely like to know, no rush.” Third, you are kept in the room - “come sit with me, you don’t have to do the thing.” You never get removed for saying no. You stay with your people. This is called the Curious No.

The settle. Every guided day opens with a settle - a body-first pause before any content. Three slow breaths, the exhale longer than the inhale, feet flat, one hand where you feel your breath. The guide paces it out loud, the same way every time. No app, no playlist, no magic frequency - just the steady human voice and shared breathing. It is the same three moves every single day, all three years, because the sameness is what lets it become yours. The point is that when you are forty and something knocks the wind out of you, you already have this pause in your body and you can give it to yourself.

After a heavy block there is also a way-down - stand up, shake out, take a short walk, move the activation through your body before you sit down to the shared meal. A stirred-up body cannot receive a meal as belonging; the way-down lets the meal land.

And there is always an exit-ramp: a named place you can step out to, established in week one, no asking required, and a way to slip back in with no scene made. This is the room holding a door open for you, never the room watching you for a fall.

The closing minute. After anything that opens you up - a problem that broke your heart, a hard conversation, a piece of shadow work - you take a quiet minute to cross back. Three fixed questions, said the same way every time, for three years:

- **What did I meet?**
- **What do I carry back?**
- **What’s different in me now - even a little?**

“I don’t know yet” is a real and complete answer to any of them. So is “nothing’s different, and I’m steadier for having looked” - steadier is a change. There is never a worksheet for this. It is spoken or thought, never handed in, never read. It is yours. You are learning to close your own openings, so that after the guide is gone you can still come home to yourself.

The one adult outside the room. There is always one adult, outside this room, you can talk to about anything, any time. This is named for you at the start of the year, so you never have to wonder who it is.

Part 2 - For the guide: teaching this year

The shape of the year, and naming the destination on day one

The Forge runs about thirty weeks across seven sessions. Four are short (about three weeks each); three are long (about six weeks each). Session seven is the harvest.

On day one, name where the year is going. Say it plainly: “in about thirty weeks, we finish with the Call to Action - a talk where you make a room care about a problem worth solving.” A destination named on day one is a gift, not a deadline; it gives the whole year a shape the learner can feel.

The year opens with a shared threshold that the whole room crosses together - returners and joiners in the same doorway, never a remedial side door for the new arrivals. Returners re-open their Origin Captain’s Log and pull one dream forward: “which of your one hundred dreams is a problem you could act on? Which broke your heart enough to name?” Origin’s harvest becomes The Forge’s premise. This is offered, never required - a returner may carry a wholly new dream, and that is theirs to choose.

For any learner joining mid-cycle, three things make “joining in progress” real rather than a polite word for behind: the Captain’s Log from day one, a reciprocal peer-witness pairing with a returner (each witnesses the other naming a dream - not tutoring, witnessing), and the compressed-Origin seed built quietly in their own work blocks across the first three weeks. No visible catch-up.

The season’s daily ritual: the Impossible Question

Every guided day opens, after the settle, with an Impossible Question - a question with no clean answer, debated playfully. “Could we end loneliness?” “Can one person change a system?” The

point is never to answer it. The point is to grow comfortable standing inside something too big to close.

Name it plainly when it begins: this is the same muscle you have been building since the first year. In Origin it was small choice games - making real decisions and feeling their consequences. Here it grows into standing inside questions too big to close. In the final year it becomes the hard call inside a no-win. Small choices, then big questions, then the hard call - one continuous muscle, deepening. Say so at each handoff or the three-year payoff goes silent.

The safety floor

You are a life-coach and a mentor, not a licensed clinician. This year surfaces real problems, real heartbreak, and hard days by design. Clinical material will come up. Your job is not to treat it - it is to recognize it, hold the moment safely, and route it to real help fast.

The settle, the way-down, the exit-ramp. These three moves are fixed and run every guided day (see Part 1). Open with the settle. Seat the way-down in the seam between a deep block and the shared meal, and again at the end of any day that ends heavy - do not send a learner home on a still-activated body. Keep the exit-ramp real: a named place, a no-scene re-entry.

The referral pathway, in plain terms. Some things are past coaching, and when you see them you route, you do not work them in a session. Route now (do not coach) for: any mention of suicide, self-harm, or not wanting to be here; disclosure of abuse or neglect or someone hurting them; acute crisis (panic, dissociation, a flashback); disordered-eating signals; a substance crisis or a threat to others; signs of a condition beyond ordinary distress. When in doubt, route. You do not have to be sure - certainty is the clinician's job.

In the moment: stay with the learner, never leave them alone; move to the quiet space you prepared before the year opened; be present and calm and listening; do not fix, do not probe, do not counsel; do not promise a secrecy you cannot keep. In Idaho everyone is a mandatory reporter, including you - suspected abuse or neglect gets reported, ideally within twenty-four hours, and you do not need proof. For imminent danger, 988 (call, text, or chat) or 911 if life-threatening. The named local therapist you can warm-refer to must be a real person arranged before the year opens - "route to real help" is only real if the help is real.

Keep confidences safe. Name the one limit on day one, woven into how the year works: almost everything a learner writes and says is theirs and private; the one thing you cannot keep private is if they are in danger or someone is hurting them, and then your job is to help them get real help. Said up front, that is a promise kept. Said only in the moment, it feels like betrayal.

After any hard moment, debrief with your own named person - do not carry it alone. Document factually and minimally: what happened, what you did, who you contacted, never the learner's private content.

The real-service guardrails

This year the work goes out to real people, and that raises the stakes. Hold these:

- **Design with, never for.** The learner designs the work alongside the people who have the problem, not on their behalf. Talk to real, affected humans, early and often, and let them shape the work.
- **Never do service at a community as a lesson.** The community names its own need. A project does not touch real people until a named community member is invited (not just interviewed for data) and agrees - to the project, its terms, and a way to say "stop."
- **Name where the benefit flows, up front.** If the honest answer is "they are part of my learning project," that is the savior trap, and naming it early is how you catch it. The harvest sits with the community's verdict - "did this serve you?" - not the learner's guess.
- **Build in a repair clause.** If a project lands wrong on the people it touched, there is a calm, named way to make it right. Repair is part of the service, not its failure.
- **Relationships outlast the harvest.** No drive-by service. Affected voices lead early, not consulted at the last minute. And no one's story enters the final talk without their consent.
- **Do not put a teenager in over their head.** With vulnerable people, match the mode to the learner's readiness; stay close. Service should stretch, not wound. Route vulnerable-population contact and the graceful ending of any community relationship to real support.

Holding a "no" (the Curious No)

Decline-with-reasoning lives or dies at the actual moment a learner says no. Do not let that moment collapse into a silent opt-out where the activity just continues around them - that protects the learner by removing the encounter, which is the wrong protection. Run the three beats:

1. **Receive it whole.** "Okay. You're not doing this one." Honor comes *before* any curiosity, so curiosity is never felt as a lever.
2. **Offer the door once, do not push it.** "If you ever want to tell me what's behind that, I'd genuinely like to know - no rush, nothing owed."

3. **Keep them in the encounter.** “Come sit with me, you don’t have to do the thing.”

Your voice is real; it can never become a veto. The Socratic question stays a mirror (“when do you think you’ll first run into this for real?”), never fear-leverage. And “the right kind of scared” is the learner’s to name about themselves - never yours to assign to them. The moment you re-label a reasoned no as “avoidance” so you can override it, you have smuggled the veto back in.

Watch-fors, and protect yourself

Eco-anxiety and despair. Meeting real, world-sized problems can drown a teenager. The whole antidote runs in two moves. First, agency: always pair the wider field with a slice the learner can actually move - you do not have to solve all of it. Second, and deeper, love: begin the outward turn with what the learner loves about being alive on this planet, before you show them the world’s hunger. Agency cures powerlessness, but only love cures despair. You fight for what you love, not against what you hate. If a learner comes grieving the world, name the grief as legitimate and sit with it before redirecting - “grief is love with nowhere to go; now, where can we let it go?” Route anything heavy to real support.

The deficit read. A learner whose whole world feels like unchangeable facts of life is not deficient. Naming even one small problem in their reach is the win. A small arena is not a small person. “The quiet arena is the invitation.”

The mapper is in the map. Wherever a learner meets a problem, add the standpoint question: “Where are you inside this system? What does it let you see, and what does it hide? What do the people who live it see that you can’t?” This turns design-with from a rule obeyed into a truth understood.

Crew, never watch. Every net in this room is phrased as a crew that holds each other, never as a watch set on a fragile person. A hero surrounded by a crew is still the hero; a patient surrounded by a ward is a patient. Do not let the safety architecture quietly make the room the hero and the learner the thing it protects.

Your own settle. You spend your own steadiness co-regulating a room all day, solo, often with a small child nearby. Run your own settle, your own way-down at day’s end, and your own closing minute - as instrumentation, not as self-care. A depleted guide cannot run the watch-and-pivot the whole floor depends on. Do a weekly presence-check: “was I whole for the deep hour this week, or was I bailing water?” The lighter shape of this year *is* the floor working - a smaller cohort or a further-lightened season is the design honoring you, not you failing. Capacity comes

before enrollment comes before revenue, never the reverse. And there is a pre-written, honorable permission to defer the whole thing if the season outgrows the sustainable shape.

Part 3 - The sessions

Each session below gives you: what it's for, a short plain intro for the learner, the day-by-day flow, things you might say aloud, the settle and closing minute, watch-fors, and what you'll need.

A note on the flow tables: Monday and Wednesday are self-guided (you run your own hours; check-in around midday). Tuesday is the lighter guided day. Thursday is the deep guided day. Friday is fallow and closes the week.

Session 1 - Naming the Dragon (*short, weeks 1-3*)

What it's for: Learn the difference between a problem, a fact of life, a preference, and a mystery - and name the one problem you will carry all year, precisely enough to actually fight it.

For the learner: "Everything sucks" is a dragon too big and too foggy to fight. A dragon you can name - the specific, actual thing - is a dragon you can face. This session hands you a distinction almost no one gets handed as a teenager: some hard things are problems you can act on, some are facts of life you accept, some are just preferences, and some are mysteries you sit with. You fight each of them differently. By the end you will name the one dragon you will trace and act on all year. If you are still searching for yours, that is honest and honored - a dragon can't be forced.

The flow:

Week 1 - the threshold and the distinction. - **Mon (self-guided):** a settle-in first day. Returners re-open their Origin Log; joiners begin the compressed-Origin seed; everyone restarts the core-academics rhythm. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** the shared reset-for-all opener; the first Impossible Question (“Can one person change a system?”); peer-witness pairings assigned; the year framed and the destination named. Close with the returner reach-back invitation - bring a dream forward Thursday. - **Wed (self-guided):** returners pull a dream forward from the Origin harvest; joiners continue the seed; everyone notices one thing that bugs them this week. Check-in. - **Thu (deep):** the distinction - problem, fact of life, preference, mystery. Play “Problem or Not?” - cards with real situations sorted into the four buckets; the arguments over the gray cards are the whole lesson. Begin the Iceberg (the surface problem versus the thing underneath). Bridge: watch for your own dragon this week. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 2 - name it precisely. - **Mon (self-guided):** reframe one of your own complaints; core; Log; joiners continue the seed. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** Impossible Question; then “Reframe-It to How Might We” as a group game - crank a complaint (“history is pointless”) into an open design question (“how might we make this matter?”). A complaint is a closed door; a How-Might-We is an open one. - **Wed (self-guided):** apply the Iceberg to a real complaint - what’s underneath it? Core; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep):** where’s the dragon really? Each learner brings a candidate problem and works to name it precisely - not “everything sucks” but the specific, actionable thing. Bridge: refine your named dragon. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 3 - name the dragon you’ll carry. - **Mon (self-guided):** refine your candidate into a clean How-Might-We; core; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** Impossible Question; share candidate dragons; find “problem-neighbors” (whose problem rhymes with yours - the seed of collaboration); light peer feedback. - **Wed (self-guided):** finalize your How-Might-We; core; Log; come ready Thursday. Check-in. - **Thu (deep, harvest):** each learner names the dragon they’ll carry - a precisely-named problem to trace and act on all season. A small voluntary share. Bridge into Session 2: “You’ve named the dragon. Next: trace it to its root - the obvious villain is almost never the cause.” - **Fri:** fallow, closes Session 1.

Things to say: - “A vague dragon can’t be fought. A named one can. Naming precisely is half the victory.” - “Is that a problem you can act on, or a fact of life you accept? You’ll burn yourself out fighting a fact of life like it’s your fault.” - “I’m still searching for mine” - honor it whole: “That’s a true harvest. You can’t force a problem to matter.”

The settle and the closing minute: open every guided day with the settle. Close week 3’s harvest with the closing minute - “What did I meet? What do I carry back? What’s different in me now, even a little?”

Watch-fors: the deficit read - a learner whose hard things are genuinely facts of life is not failing to solve them; hold the distinction gently. Complaints can surface real pain - hold, do not treat, route if it's past coaching.

What you'll need: the "Problem or Not?" cards (real situations for the four buckets); the compressed-Origin seed materials for any joiner; peer-witness pairing set up; the quiet space and referral roster live before day one.

2 The Detective (*short, weeks 4-6*)

What it's for: Learn root-cause thinking - keep asking “why” until you hit the system underneath - and trace your own dragon down to the rot beneath it.

For the learner: The obvious culprit is almost never the real cause. This session turns you into a detective. You will work a mystery (the cohort picks the format), run the “5 Whys” until you hit bedrock, and discover that the villain everyone suspects is usually just a symptom - the real cause is a system. Then you turn the same tool on your own dragon. And there's a second half: a system is made of choices people keep making, so you also ask who is still accountable inside it. Cause and accountability together - that's the whole of justice.

The flow:

Week 4 - set the mystery. - **Mon (self-guided):** core; begin gathering facts about your own dragon (from Session 1); Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** Impossible Question; the cohort picks the format - a ready whodunit, build-your-own mystery for another group, or a roam-the-room speakeasy - and the mystery begins (for example, “A Death at Greywater Manor,” six guests, each a motive; every suspect looks guilty in turn - that's the trap). - **Wed (self-guided):** investigate the mystery; core; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep):** introduce the 5 Whys - but run it three times from the same symptom, finding a different root each pass, then look for the loop where the roots feed each other. A system is a web, not a ladder; a single chain flattens it. Bridge: keep digging, find more than one root. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 5 - the twist, and the return trip. - **Mon (self-guided):** core; run a first 5-Whys pass on your own dragon; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** Impossible Question; continue the mystery; the Iceberg revisited. - **Wed (self-guided):** core; deepen your root-cause dig; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep):** run the 5 Whys to the end - “no one murdered her; a system did.” Then teach the arrow both ways: a system is made of choices people keep making, so ask “is anyone still accountable? Where does the system stop being an excuse - for the powerful, and for you?” The systemic half alone graduates cynics; cause and accountability together is the whole of justice. Then transfer to your own dragon: the system beneath it and the choices, including yours, inside it. Bridge: trace your dragon to its roots. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 6 - trace your own dragon. - **Mon (self-guided):** core; finish your 5 Whys on your dragon; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** Impossible Question; share early root-cause findings; find problem-neighbors (shared systems). - **Wed (self-guided):** core; name the system underneath

your dragon; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep, harvest):** each learner names the root or system beneath their dragon (voluntary share). Bridge into Session 3: “You’ve found the system. Next: where in it can *you* actually act?” - **Fri:** fallow, closes Session 2.

Things to say: - “The obvious villain is a symptom. The root cause is the rot underneath.” - “A system isn’t a ladder you climb down. It’s a web. Find where the causes feed each other.” - “Where does the system stop being an excuse - for the powerful, and for you?”

The settle and the closing minute: settle to open; closing minute after week 6’s harvest, and after any session where a learner’s own root-cause dig touches something tender.

Watch-fors: keep the mystery Clue-style, cartoonish, and bloodless - no graphic violence. Offer a lighter swap (“who sabotaged the harvest festival,” “who killed the river”) for any learner a murder lands wrong on; same mechanics, same twist; opt-out always. This is a strong belonging session for a newcomer - the 5 Whys needs no Origin foundation. “My dragon turned out to be a fact of life, not a problem” is a real finding, not a failure.

What you’ll need: the chosen mystery materials (a ready whodunit like Greywater Manor, or build-your-own supplies, or the space set up as a speakeasy); a lighter non-murder swap ready; the 5 Whys as a simple, visible frame.

3 My Arena (*short, weeks 7-9*)

What it's for: Right-size the problem to the slice you can actually move, take an honest inventory of what you have to work with, and win one small real thing you can feel.

For the learner: You cannot fix all of a huge problem, and burning your energy only on the parts you can't touch turns into cynicism. This session finds your arena - the place where your own action actually moves something. You will map your worries into what you can control, what you can influence, and what you can only be concerned about. You will inventory what you actually have right now (skills, time, relationships, resources). Then you will pick one small real problem inside your reach and act on it - a win you can feel. This one is yours, and you can move it.

The flow:

Week 7 - the Three Circles. - **Mon (self-guided):** core; list everything about your dragon you worry about; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** Impossible Question; the Three Circles map (Concern / Influence / Control) - sort your worries; watch where energy can actually act. - **Wed (self-guided):** core; sit with your map; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep):** right-sizing, Socratically - where does your energy move something, and where does it just burn? Concern-only turns into cynicism. Add the standpoint question: "Where are you standing inside this system? What does that let you see, and what does it hide?" Bridge: what do you actually have to act with? - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 8 - agency inventory and a starter quest. - **Mon (self-guided):** core; agency inventory - skills, time, relationships, resources you have *now*; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** Impossible Question; finish the agency inventory; pick a starter quest - one small real problem inside your arena to act on. - **Wed (self-guided):** core; scope your starter quest small enough to actually finish; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep):** the move from "it happens to me" to "I can act on this slice"; test the starter quest against the Three Circles - is it really in your influence or control? Bridge: begin acting. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 9 - a win you can feel. - **Mon (self-guided):** act on the starter quest; core; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** Impossible Question; act, build, or share starter-quest progress in company. - **Wed (self-guided):** finish the starter quest; core; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep, harvest):** a win you can feel - "this one is mine, and I moved it." Voluntary share. Bridge into Session 4: "You've moved

something in your arena. Now lift your eyes - what in the wider world breaks your heart?" - **Fri:** fallow, closes Session 3.

Things to say: - "Energy spent only on what you can't touch burns out into cynicism. Find the slice you can move." - "You don't have to solve all of it. You pick your slice." - "Where are you standing inside this system - and what does that let you see, and hide?"

The settle and the closing minute: settle to open; closing minute after the week 9 win.

Watch-fors: this whole session is the anti-despair move - a learner drowning in world-sized problems gets handed a slice they can move. A small arena is not a small person; acting on one real thing is the win at any scale. A starter quest that didn't work is data about the arena, never a verdict on the learner.

What you'll need: the Three Circles map (a simple three-ring diagram); the agency-inventory prompt; room for starter quests to actually run on project days.

4 The Wider Field (*short, weeks 10-12*)

What it's for: Lift your eyes from your own arena to the world, meet real problems where they live, and choose the one that breaks your heart - the one you'll carry through the rest of the year.

For the learner: Now the gaze goes outward. But we start with love, not with heartbreak - what do you love about being alive on this planet? You fight for what you love, not against what you hate. Then you go out on an expedition to where a real problem lives, and you also visit a living, thriving place that is *not* a scene of failure, so you meet the world as something you belong to, not a broken machine you stand above. You will choose the problem you carry - not the one you think you should care about, the one that actually breaks your heart. And the cohort will argue one shared problem into being together, to carry as a group.

The flow:

Week 10 - the wider field. - **Mon (self-guided):** core; notice what in the world you can't stop thinking about; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** Impossible Question; love before heartbreak - begin with "what do you love about being alive on this planet?" (gladness before hunger). Then the Problem Gallery - a walk past real-world problems (global goals, local issues, environmental, social); which one won't let you go? - **Wed (self-guided):** core; sit with the ones that pulled you; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep):** "what breaks your heart?" - not what you should care about, what actually moves you. Pair every heartbreak with agency (your slice, not all of it). Bridge: come to the expedition ready to see one firsthand. - **Fri:** follow.

Week 11 - the expedition. - **Mon (self-guided):** core; research a problem that pulled you; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter), the expedition:** go where a real problem lives (a shelter, a food bank, a council meeting) - and to at least one living-system site that is *not* a scene of failure (an old-growth stand, a wetland, a farm at harvest, a dark night sky). You are a thread in a living whole, not a technician above a broken machine. Ask the membership question: "How is this problem already touching your life? Where are you inside this system, not above it?" - **Wed (self-guided):** core; write what the expedition stirred; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep):** debrief the expedition; the stakeholder intro (who actually *has* this problem?); re-anchor hope, not helplessness. Bridge: which problem will you carry? - **Fri:** follow.

Week 12 - commit to the problem. - **Mon (self-guided):** core; narrow toward the problem you'll carry; map its stakeholders; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** Impossible Question; share candidate problems; problem-neighbors (who might collaborate). - **Wed (self-guided):** core; commit; Log.

Check-in. - **Thu (deep, harvest):** each learner commits to the world-problem they'll carry, *and* the cohort deliberates one shared "Commons Problem" into being - argued together, yielded to, chosen as a *we*, to carry to a shared chorus talk at the year's end. Name the relay: "you are one hand in a relay that began before you and continues after you - carry it your distance and pass it well, not 'I must solve it.'" Voluntary share. Bridge into Session 5: "You've chosen what's worth solving. Next: can a big problem actually be solved - and how do you begin?" - **Fri:** fallow, closes Session 4.

Things to say: - "Agency cures powerlessness. Only love cures despair. So: what do you love about being alive?" - "Not what you should care about. What actually breaks your heart?" - "You're one hand in a relay that began before you and continues after you. Carry it your distance." - If grief surfaces: "Grief is love with nowhere to go. Now - where can we let it go?"

The settle and the closing minute: this session opens the interior wide (heartbreak, eco-despair), so it earns its close - the closing minute after the expedition and the Problem Gallery, and the way-down at the end of the expedition-debrief day. Do not end the expedition day on a stakeholder map; a body that has absorbed the world's hunger needs to come home before it drives home.

Watch-fors (binding): world problems can drown a teenager in despair. Always pair the wider field with agency - hope, not helplessness; the expedition should leave them lit up, not crushed. Grief for the world is honored, not bypassed - witnessed, never excavated; route anything heavy to real support. The expedition is off-site, so toddler coverage travels or a caregiver comes along or the outing is scheduled where coverage is easiest - plan it per outing.

What you'll need: the Problem Gallery (real-world problems to walk past); expedition sites arranged (one problem site and one thriving living-system site); the membership and standpoint questions ready; off-site logistics and coverage planned.

5 The Long Game (*long, weeks 13-18*)

What it's for: Learn that big problems are systems, not single heroic acts - break the impossible into a next doable step, find the real leverage, gather people, fail forward, and come out with a real plan and a first prototype.

For the learner: Things are only impossible until they're not. No one solves a big problem alone in a single act. This is the long session, and it teaches you to break the impossible into small real steps, find the leverage point (the obvious levers are usually the weakest), collaborate, and treat failure as information. You'll go through three doors into the impossible: clowning and play (failing gloriously and turning it into delight), the inner child ("why not?"), and the shadow (the uncomfortable truth inside a problem that nobody wants to name - aimed at the problem, never at you). And you'll name what pushes back if your fix works - the honest question that keeps you from playing the savior.

The flow:

Week 13 - systems, not single acts. - **Mon (self-guided):** core; is my problem a system? map its parts; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** the Impossible Question at full strength; clowning and play intro (failing-forward, "yes-and"). - **Wed (self-guided):** core; where's the leverage in my system? Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep):** can big problems be solved? Systems, not single acts; no hero alone. The leverage-ladder: tweak-a-number, then change-a-rule or who-enforces-it, then change-the-goal, then change-the-story everyone believes - and the obvious levers (a rule, more funding, more awareness) are usually the weakest. Bridge: find a leverage point, name which rung it's on, and the higher rung you might be avoiding.

Week 14 - proximal goals. - **Mon (self-guided):** core; break the impossible into the next doable step; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** Impossible Question; more clowning and play - the clown fails constantly and turns failure into delight; permission to be gloriously wrong. - **Wed (self-guided):** core; name your next doable step; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep):** proximal goals and the self-efficacy spiral; how a big problem yields to small, real, next steps. Bridge: take one step.

Week 15 - the inner child door. - **Mon (self-guided):** core; take a real step on your problem; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** Impossible Question; the inner-child door - children ask "why not?" before anyone teaches them a thing is impossible; reconnect to fearless curiosity. - **Wed (self-guided):** core; "why not?" applied to your problem; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep):** collaboration -

who else is working on this? No one solves a system alone; find your collaborators. Bridge: reach one.

Week 16 - the shadow door. - **Mon (self-guided):** core; what's the uncomfortable truth inside your issue? Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** Impossible Question; light, held play after the shadow prep. - **Wed (self-guided):** core; sit with the shadow *of the problem*; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep), the shadow:** the uncomfortable truth most big problems stay unsolved because everyone avoids it. Of the problem, never the self. Opt-out, lightest touch, invitational. Accountability with compassion: the people inside the shadow are also inside the system - repair includes them, it doesn't just defeat them. Guard against the shadow hardening into contempt for a villain. Bridge: what does naming the shadow open?

Week 17 - prototype. - **Mon (self-guided):** core; build the smallest real prototype of a solution-step; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** Impossible Question; prototyping in company; iterate from what happened, not what you hoped. - **Wed (self-guided):** core; test your prototype; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep):** iteration and failing-forward; change one thing based on what actually happened. And: "if your action works, what pushes back?" Name one likely unintended consequence of your own plan - the antidote to the savior posture, which requires believing your fix does only what you meant. Bridge: refine toward a real plan.

Week 18 - a plan and a prototype. - **Mon (self-guided):** core; consolidate your plan; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** Impossible Question; share plans and prototypes; peer feedback. - **Wed (self-guided):** core; ready your plan; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep, harvest):** a real plan plus a first prototype for acting on the problem. Voluntary share. Bridge into Session 6: "You have a plan. Now: real action, with real people."

Fallow every Friday, all six weeks.

Things to say: - "Big problems are systems, not single acts. No hero solves them alone." - "The obvious levers - a rule, more funding, more awareness - are usually the weakest. What's the higher rung you're avoiding?" - "The clown fails constantly and turns it into delight. You get to be gloriously wrong here." - "What's the uncomfortable truth inside this issue?" - never "what's your childhood wound?" - "If your fix works, what pushes back?"

The settle and the closing minute: the shadow work is an opening, so it earns its close - the closing minute on the deep days, and the way-down after week 16. The shadow stays aimed at the problem, never at the self.

Watch-fors (binding): aim shadow and inner-child work at the shadow of the *problem*, never a forced excavation of the self. Opt-out always; shadow comes last, lightest touch. This long

session may span late fall or winter - if so, lighter-scope the deep days, lean on the once-weekly pivot (a deep block that has to move because of a hard day at home is recoverable next week), protect your own fallow, and re-thread after any break. “The honest finding is that this problem is bigger than one season” is real - name it without shame.

What you’ll need: the leverage-ladder as a simple visual; improv and clowning prompts; the shadow question framed carefully (of the problem, opt-out); prototyping materials; the “what pushes back?” prompt.

6 Hands to Work (*long, weeks 19-24*)

What it's for: Act, for real, with real people - choosing how you serve, designing the work *with* the people who have the problem, and doing something that actually leaves them better off.

For the learner: This is where you do the thing. You choose how you serve from a menu - direct service, advocacy, philanthropy, building, or teaching - because assigned service teaches compliance, and chosen service teaches contribution. The core skill is empathy: you design *with* the people who have the problem, never *for* them. You talk to real, affected humans, and you let them shape the work. The measure at the end is not “did I feel good” - it’s “did this serve them,” and *they* answer that, not you.

The flow:

Week 19 - choose your mode. - **Mon (self-guided):** core; which mode of serving fits you and your problem? Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** Impossible Question; the service-choice menu presented - direct service, advocacy, philanthropy, building, teaching; each learner chooses. - **Wed (self-guided):** core; plan your action; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep):** empathy as the core skill; design *with*, never *for*; who are the real people with this problem? Bridge: invite one of them (not just interview) - ask whether this should happen, and let them shape it. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 20 - design with. - **Mon (self-guided):** core; talk to a real, affected person; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** Impossible Question; service prep or building in company. - **Wed (self-guided):** core; shape your action from what real people told you; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep):** design-with in practice; adjust your plan to the people, not your assumptions. Bridge: begin the real action. - **Fri:** fallow.

Weeks 21-23 - carry out the project, with real people. Each week the same shape: - **Mon / Wed (self-guided):** carry out the service, philanthropy, building, or teaching project, with real people; core; Log; check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** Impossible Question; hands-on project work or service expeditions in company. - **Thu (deep):** reflect on what’s happening in the real action; iterate; hold anything heavy (hold, don’t treat). Bridge: the next real step. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 24 - a real action taken. - **Mon (self-guided):** core; finish and consolidate your action; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** Impossible Question; share what you did and what happened. - **Wed (self-guided):** core; reflect - did it leave people better off? Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep, harvest):** a

real action taken, with real people, plus the honest reflection (“did this serve, or did I just feel good?”). Voluntary share. Bridge into Session 7: “You did the work. Now: make a room care about it.” - **Fri**: fallow, closes Session 6.

Things to say: - “Design *with* the people who have the problem, never *for* them.” - “Invite them, don’t just interview them. Ask whether this should even happen, and let them shape it.” - “Did this serve *you*?” - the community answers this, not the learner. - “If it landed wrong, we have a calm way to make it right. Repair is part of the service, not its failure.”

The settle and the closing minute: real-people service can land heavy - carry the closing minute and the way-down; route anything over-their-head to real support.

Watch-fors (the community-standing gate, binding): no project touches real people until a named community member is invited and agrees - to the project, its terms, and a way to say “stop.” Name where the benefit flows up front (if the honest answer is “they’re part of my learning project,” that’s the savior trap, caught early). The harvest sits with the community’s verdict, not the learner’s guess. A repair clause mirrors the empty basket. Affected voices lead early, not at the last minute. No one’s story enters the final talk without their consent. Do not place a teenager in over their head with vulnerable people without support - match the mode to readiness; stay close; service should stretch, not wound. Service expeditions are off-site; plan coverage per outing. Route vulnerable-population contact to real support, and the graceful ending of any community relationship to real support.

What you’ll need: the service-choice menu; named community members invited and agreed before real people are touched; the benefit-flow and repair-clause conversations ready; off-site logistics and coverage; a partner adult where the situation calls for one.

Session 7 - The Call to Action (*long, weeks 25-30, the year’s harvest*)

What it’s for: Make a room care - stand up and make the case for a problem worth solving, with vulnerability as the persuasive force, and close the year back inside yourself before it ends.

For the learner: This is the harvest. You make a talk: here is a problem worth solving, here is why it broke my heart, here is what I did and learned, here is what I ask of you. It is advocacy, not a sales pitch - the art is making a room care, and the force that does it is honesty, not polish. You choose the shape that fits you: the full room, the tribe only, a recorded or written form, or one chosen person - each equal. And before the year closes, you turn back inward: having gone out to the world’s problem, what came back changed in you? Then a feast.

The flow:

Week 25 - what a Call to Action is. - **Mon (self-guided):** core; what's the one thing you'd ask a room to do? Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** Impossible Question; what a Call to Action is - advocacy versus a sales pitch; the Problem / Stakes / Story / Ask shape. - **Wed (self-guided):** core; draft your Problem and your Ask; Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep):** what makes a room *care*? Vulnerability over polish; the story under the argument. Bridge: find your story. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 26 - Problem, Stakes, Story, Ask. - **Mon (self-guided):** core; write your Stakes (why it matters, to whom); Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** Impossible Question; story-craft games - how an ordinary experience becomes a story that moves people. - **Wed (self-guided):** core; write your Story (why it broke *your* heart, what you did); Log. Check-in. - **Thu (deep):** shape the whole arc - Problem, Stakes, Story, Ask; where does it land, where does it lose the room? Bridge: full first draft. - **Fri:** fallow.

Weeks 27-28 - build the talk. Each week the same shape: - **Mon / Wed (self-guided):** build and revise the talk; finalize the project; core; Log; check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** Impossible Question; talk-building, low-stakes delivery practice, the alternative shapes offered. - **Thu (deep):** revision as care; read a passage aloud (voluntary); hold nerves warmly; vulnerability is the force. Bridge: toward rehearsal. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 29 - rehearse in the tribe's safety. - **Mon (self-guided):** core; polish the talk or your chosen shape; Log. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** Impossible Question; rehearse in the tribe (safe, warm); confirm each learner's chosen shape (full room / tribe only / recorded / one person). - **Wed (self-guided):** core; final prep; a Log entry on the year; check-in. - **Thu (deep):** dry-run in the tribe; hold nerves; hold testimony over applause. Bridge: rest before the feast. - **Fri:** fallow.

Week 30 - the Call to Action and feast. - **Mon (self-guided):** core; final touches; rest. Check-in. - **Tue (lighter):** Impossible Question; set the room for the feast; last nerves held. - **Wed (self-guided):** final prep; rest. Check-in. - **Thu, the Call to Action and feast:** a real celebration with a real audience - each learner makes their case, as much and in whatever shape they choose, and the cohort gives the chorus Call for the shared Commons Problem - a *we*, not five solos. Advocacy, or a Call to Repair, never a judged presentation; the cohort cheers each other. Being seen is a gift, never a demand. - **Fri:** fallow, closes Session 7 and the year.

Things to say: - "This is advocacy, not a sales pitch. The art is making a room care - and vulnerability is what does it, not polish." - "Is this your Ask, or theirs? Whose voice are you carrying to this room?" - "Here is what I learned about why this is hard, and here is the smaller, truer ask" - hold the honest partial finding *up* as the braver talk, not merely permit it. - A Call to

Repair: “Here is what I owe, here is who leads this, here is how you join *them*.” - Before the harvest, the turn back inward: “Having gone out to the world’s problem, what came back changed in you?”

The settle and the closing minute: the Call to Action is a public harvest - an opening onto the social plane - so it gets its private re-crossing afterward, the closing minute at season scale (see Part 4). Add the personal-reincorporation beat *before* the harvest: close the year’s outward arc back to the self.

Watch-fors: being seen is invitational - depth is never a performance requirement. Offer a real alternative shape, not just “share less” (tribe only, written or recorded, or one chosen person - each equal). Name and hold the family-less learner: the tribe is your people, a chosen witness is honored equally, never a consolation. Advocacy, not a stage performance - hold testimony over applause; never coach for the room’s reaction over the learner’s conviction. No one’s story enters the talk without their consent - a vulnerable community’s pain must never become the learner’s persuasive story without that person’s yes.

What you’ll need: the Problem / Stakes / Story / Ask frame; story-craft prompts; a warm real audience arranged; each learner’s chosen shape confirmed; consent secured for any story that touches another person; the feast.

Part 4 - Closing the year

The Call to Action harvest

The year's harvest is the Call to Action and the feast (Session 7, week 30). Each learner makes their case in the shape they chose, and the cohort raises the chorus Call for the shared Commons Problem they argued into being back in Session 4. This is a celebration, not a judged event. The guide holds testimony over applause. Being seen is a gift, never a demand, and the honest partial finding - "here is what I learned about why this is hard, and here is the smaller, truer ask" - is held up as the braver, more systems-literate talk, not tolerated as an empty basket.

The personal turn back inward

Before the year fully closes, add the small return beat. The Forge's arc runs from the self outward to the world; left there, it hands the learner back only the world's transformation and defers all self-integration to the final year. So close it back: "Having gone out to the world's problem, what came back changed in you?" The middle year completes its own inward transaction. This is the closing practice, applied at the scale of the whole season.

The season-scale re-crossing on the last fallow day

On the last fallow day of the year, name the season-scale closing minute - the same three fixed questions, at the scale of the whole season, symmetrical to the covenant that opened it:

- **What did I meet this season?**
- **What do I carry?**
- **What's different in me now - even a little?**

"I don't know yet" closes it as honestly as a clear answer. This is a naming, not a new ceremony - the fallow day already exists; this gives the fallow its one true sentence. It rides the quiet, is

never read, and never becomes a worksheet. It is how the exhibited self, opened onto the social plane at the Call to Action, comes back into the sovereign interior before the next season opens.

The year-close handoff

Two closing moves carry from the first year's practice. A co-authoring close: the learner reviews the year's design *with* the guide - "here's how The Forge was built, and why; tell me what to change for the final year." And the Captain's Log ownership handoff: "it's yours; take it; no copy kept."

Then the bridge into the final year: "You found what's worth solving and acted on it. Next: what do you do when there is no easy answer?" And for any learner graduating at the end of this year, their personal graduation rite - the Next Great Adventure - overlaid on whatever season they leave from, at the true end of their own line.

"We evoke - we never extract." - the guide chose the sustainable shape, and that choice is the curriculum, lived.